

REST STOP

A Game-Design Brainstorming Conversation

Full transcript • May 28, 2026

This document is a transcript of a collaborative design session for *Rest Stop*, an absurd single-level 2-D side-scroller. It walks from a blank-page creative block to a fully specified game concept: an over-prepared road-tripper, three mischievous dogs, a cop-calling stranger, and a setting sun. Speaker turns are color-coded — **blue** for the user, **green** for the game designer, and **amber** for the interactive multiple-choice prompts.

USER

[Game brief] Create a single player, 2-D side scrolling game. Your game should have a protagonist with a backstory and motivation, a set of moves and actions to navigate the obstacles of the game, a way of scoring points or health, a way of losing points or health, and an endgame condition that signifies the end of the level. Your game should have at least one level. Your game should have at least three main screens: A title screen, the gameplay screen for playing levels, and a high scores summary screen. Your game must store high scores with editable three character initials and be able to persist them over time (local storage please, no cloud storage or internet access required).

We're going to talk this through, so don't get ahead of yourself.

CLAUDE (game designer)

Love it — the best games start from a feeling or a hook, not a feature list. Let's find the seed first and worry about scoring, screens, and storage later.

Side-scrollers are great because the core fantasy reads instantly: you're *moving through* a world, left to right, overcoming what's in your way. So the first question I want to nail is **what that world feels like and who you are in it**.

Before I throw concepts at you, one quick gut-check to point us in a direction:

INTERACTIVE PROMPT

[Question] When you picture this game, which vibe pulls at you most?

- Cozy & whimsical
- Tense & high-stakes
- Funny & absurd
- Moody & atmospheric

User selected: Funny & absurd

CLAUDE (game designer)

Excellent — absurd is the most fun to design for, because the *premise itself* does half the work. The comedy lives in three places: who you are, what you ridiculously want, and the indignities the world throws at you.

Here are a few seeds I'd happily build a whole game around. Each one has a built-in protagonist, a dumb-but-sincere motivation, and obvious comedic obstacles:

- 1. "Escape the Group Photo"** — You're a single, sentient slice of pizza fleeing your own birthday party before someone eats you. Motivation: survival, but make it petty. Obstacles: grabbing hands, hungry dogs, a toddler. Score = seconds survived + toppings retained.
- 2. "Late for My Own Wedding"** — You're a frazzled groom/bride sprinting across town because you overslept. Obstacles: traffic, pigeons, an ex handing you flyers, your own untied shoelaces. Score = punctuality, drained by every delay.
- 3. "The Great Office Coffee Run"** — You're an intern who must deliver a full, scalding latte to the CEO on the top floor before it goes cold. Health = coffee temperature.

4. **"Roomba's Revenge"** — You're a tired little robot vacuum just trying to finish your cleaning route and reach your charging dock before your battery dies. Health = battery; score = dirt collected.

5. **"Pigeon with a Sandwich"** — You're a city pigeon who stole an entire human sandwich and must fly/hop it back to your nest. Score = sandwich integrity.

A couple of these have especially clean mechanics — but I don't want to steer before I know what made *you* grin. Which of these tickled you, and was it the *character* or the *goal* that did it? Or did one of them spark a totally different idea?

USER

Actually, I have an idea, but it's rough and I don't really know who my protagonist is. Anyway, it's called "rest stop" like as in on the highway. Level one is where there is a driver with a dog who needs to go to the bathroom very badly. There is a meter gauging how badly one needs to relieve themselves, and you have to get to the bathroom before that meter reaches its full capacity, or risk an unfortunate accident. Level two, you have to get your dog out of the car and have him/her do their poo in a zone where the dog is allowed to poo. But the dog escapes the car and you have to get to the dog and scoop the poop before a "Karen" comes and berates you for not picking up after your dog. So the Karen threatening to call the cops on you, that could be a protagonist. Not sure. What are your thoughts.

CLAUDE (game designer)

Okay, "Rest Stop" is genuinely good — and here's *why* it works:

You've accidentally designed a really clean mechanical spine. Both levels are the same core tension — *a meter racing toward catastrophe while you try to reach a goal*. Level 1 it's your bladder. Level 2 it's the Karen. That repetition is a *feature*: the player learns the rhythm in level 1, then you reskin it with a social threat in level 2.

On the protagonist question — I think you're tangled up:

The Karen isn't your protagonist. She's your **antagonist** — the level-2 "boss." So your protagonist is **the driver**, and the dog is the **companion** that ties both levels together. One person, one dog, one miserable rest stop, two escalating disasters.

So the real open question is **who is this driver, specifically?** A few directions:

- **The Overprepared Road-Trip** — label-maker, spreadsheet, the whole plan collapsing.
- **The First-Time Dog Parent** — desperate to prove they're a good owner.
- **The Reluctant Pet-Sitter** — it's not even their dog.

Two things I'd love your take on:

INTERACTIVE PROMPT

[Question 1] Who's behind the wheel? (your protagonist + where the comedy comes from)

- Overprepared planner
- Anxious new dog parent
- Reluctant pet-sitter

- Something else / mix

User selected: Overprepared planner

[Question 2] Is the Karen the antagonist (and the driver is your hero across both levels)?

- Yes — Karen is the villain
- No — I want to subvert it

User selected: Yes — Karen is the villain

CLAUDE (game designer)

Perfect — that locks your spine, and the Overprepared Planner is the *richest* possible choice, because comedy is just **expectation vs. reality**, and this character walks in with the most rigid expectations imaginable.

Meet your driver: the planner with The Binder. Color-coded itinerary. Scheduled stops down to the minute. A laminated checklist. This person did not *plan* to need the bathroom — which is *exactly* why the bladder meter is so funny. Every disaster is a deviation from a plan that was supposed to be perfect. A control freak colliding with the two most uncontrollable forces on earth — **their own body and a dog.**

Now the one piece that turns this into a game with stakes: **why is this trip so important to them?** That destination is your motivation engine.

Here's where I want your gut again:

INTERACTIVE PROMPT

[Question] Why is the Planner on this road trip with the dog?

- Dog show / competition
- Family reunion / wedding
- Moving cross-country
- Something else

User dismissed the question (chose not to answer yet).

CLAUDE (game designer)

Got it — I'll stop steering. The floor's yours: tell me where you want to take it next.

USER

I'll answer your question in a minute, but I need to make sure you understand something. In level two the driver and dog have to get back to the car before the cops that Karen called show up.

CLAUDE (game designer)

Understood — and that's a great escalation. Let me play it back so we're locked:

Level 2 isn't one beat, it's a chain that ends in a getaway:

1. Get the dog out of the car (the planner's calm, scheduled "potty break")

2. The dog bolts — now it's a chase to catch them
3. Get the dog to do its business *in the designated zone*
4. Scoop the poop before Karen reaches you
5. If Karen catches you / you fail the scoop — **she calls the cops**, and that flips the level into its final phase:
6. **The getaway** — now you AND the dog have to scramble back to the car and peel out before the cops actually arrive.

So Karen isn't the *end* of the threat — she's the trigger for the real climax. The endgame condition for level 2 becomes **wheels out of the parking lot before the squad car pulls in**.

One thing to tuck in your back pocket: is the cop chase **always** the finale, or is it a **punishment branch** (only if you screw up)? Go ahead with whatever you wanted to say next.

USER

The driver is on a tight schedule and wants to get to his/her destination before nightfall sets in because they hate driving at night. The destination is his/her aunt's house, who is adopting the four elderly dogs the driver is transporting to her. If it gets dark before the driver gets to the aunt's house, the driver gets lost.

CLAUDE (game designer)

Oh, this is the piece that makes the whole thing *sing*.

Nightfall is your master clock. Up to now we had two *local* meters. What you just added is a **global** one sitting above both: daylight. Every disaster costs *time*, and time is daylight, and when daylight runs out the driver gets lost and it's game over. That single idea unifies everything:

- It's your **scoring system** — daylight remaining when you reach the destination = your score.
- It's your **ultimate fail/endgame condition**.
- It makes the per-level meters *matter beyond the level*.

The **four elderly dogs** detail complicates Level 2 in a fun way — it's not "the dog escapes," it's *herding four slow old dogs*.

Two back-pocket questions: (1) Do all four dogs matter, or is there one "problem dog"? (2) Is the cop getaway always the finale, or a punishment branch?

USER

Hold on...go back a bit. I got off track from the instructions. This is supposed to be an American Weekend Vacation theme. The stop at the rest stop is part of that vacation. So the goal is to get to my sister's vacation home before dark instead of getting to my aunt's house with her new dogs. Instead, it's my dogs in the car with me.

CLAUDE (game designer)

No problem — that correction actually *simplifies* the story without losing anything.

Theme: the great American weekend vacation. The rest stop is the classic mid-trip pit stop where everything goes sideways.

- **Protagonist:** still the Overprepared Planner.
- **Motivation:** get to **your sister's vacation home before dark**. The planner hates night driving.
- **The dogs are yours** — family, riding along. That makes the level-2 stakes personal.
- **Master clock — nightfall — survives intact.** Daylight is still your global resource, your score, and your ultimate fail condition.

One open thing: **how many dogs are riding with you?**

USER

If it gets dark, the driver gets lost as opposed to blowing up the vacay.

CLAUDE (game designer)

Right — the stakes are **literal, not figurative**:

- Daylight is the clock.
- **Sun sets before you reach your sister's place -> you get lost** — disoriented on dark, unfamiliar back roads. *That's* the game-over state.

So the fail condition is concrete and characterful. **Win = reach the sister's before dark; lose = darkness catches you first and you're lost.**

USER

I think there should be three dogs, two large (a Labrador Retriever and a Staffordshire Terrier), and one small (a Chihuahua).

CLAUDE (game designer)

Three dogs with that exact mix is *chef's kiss* — because you picked **three distinct behaviors**:

- **The Labrador (big, friendly menace):** the over-enthusiastic one. Pulls hard, wants to greet *everyone* — including the Karen.
- **The Staffordshire Terrier (big, sweet, profiled):** Staffies get unfairly stereotyped as "scary," which makes this breed *the* perfect Karen trigger. Your Staffie is a marshmallow, but the moment Karen sees him she loses it.
- **The Chihuahua (tiny, fast, chaos):** the escape artist. The obvious candidate for the dog who *bolts*.

So your three dogs split into roles: **the puller, the lightning rod, and the runner.**

Do you want to lean into those three distinct personalities as actual mechanics, or keep them more as flavor? And are all three out of the car in Level 2, or just the troublemaker?

USER

I like the idea of the three distinct personalities. What do you mean by "actual mechanics"?

CLAUDE (game designer)

Good question — it's the single most important distinction in game design.

"Flavor" means the dogs are different to *look at* but identical to *play*. Three sprites, three names, but you catch them all the exact same way. The personality is just decoration.

"Mechanics" means each dog changes what you actually have to *do* — your inputs, your timing, your risk. Like:

- **Chihuahua (the runner):** *fast and erratic*. You have to trap it against an obstacle — a timing/cornering challenge.
- **Labrador (the puller):** *strong and social*. Once leashed, it pulls you toward people. The challenge is steering.
- **Staffordshire Terrier (the lightning rod):** *calm, but radioactive to Karen*. His mechanic is **stealth/positioning** — keep him out of her line of sight.

Same three dogs, but now each one demands a *different skill* — cornering, steering, hiding. The trade-off: mechanics cost more to build and balance than flavor.

Do you want all three mechanics live at once in Level 2, or introduced one at a time?

USER

what do you mean by "live at once"?

CLAUDE (game designer)

Sure — "live at once" just means **how many of those dog-problems you're juggling at the same moment**.

All at once (simultaneous): all three dogs spill out and all three mechanics are active together. Chaotic, frantic, funny — but hard, and it can overwhelm a new player.

One at a time (staggered): the dogs become problems in sequence. Each mechanic gets taught in isolation. Gentler, clearer — but less chaotic.

The common hybrid: teach them *one at a time* early, then **combine them at the climax**. You get the gentle learning curve *and* the frantic payoff.

So: frantic juggle from the start, calm one-thing-at-a-time, or the ramp-up-then-combine hybrid?

USER

ramp-up-the-combine is what I'm looking for

CLAUDE (game designer)

Perfect — ramp-up-then-combine it is.

Level 2 — beat by beat:

1. **You arrive and open the car door** — calm planner energy.
2. **The Chihuahua bolts first** -> you learn **cornering** in isolation.

3. **The Lab gets loose** -> now you learn **steering**.

4. **The Staffie wanders off** -> you learn **hiding**.

5. **The combine / climax** — all three are live at once *and* now you've got to accomplish the goal: get a dog to do its business **in the designated zone**, then **scoop it** — all while **Karen's meter climbing**.

6. **The getaway** — if Karen's meter fills, **she calls the cops**, and the level flips to the escape.

Each phase also quietly **burns daylight**. Still open: is step 6 always the finale, or only a punishment branch? I'd lean toward **punishment branch**.

USER

I think I might scratch level one

CLAUDE (game designer)

That's a legitimate move, not a retreat.

The spec only requires "at least one level." And the dog level is your stronger, more original idea. The bathroom-dash is funny on paper, but generic. The dog-juggling level is *yours*.

You also don't *lose* anything mechanically by cutting Level 1:

- The "meter racing to catastrophe" idea? Still fully alive as **Karen's meter**.
- The tutorial role? The dog level **already teaches itself** via the ramp-up-then-combine structure.
- The daylight clock? Still the spine.

One thing worth preserving: the "pull into the rest stop, desperate" arrival is a great cold-open. You could fold a *shrunk-down* version into the very start of the single level.

What's making you want to scratch it — scope, the bathroom humor, or redundancy?

USER

The bathroom visit seems very separate from the dogs, but I like the idea of starting with a quick dash to the restroom. It wasn't an expected stop, so there has to be a reason for the driver to stop beyond just letting the dogs out for their scheduled break.

CLAUDE (game designer)

That's exactly the right instinct. The fix isn't to *connect* two separate events — it's to make one *cause* the other.

What forces an uptight control freak off their perfect itinerary? **Their own bladder**. A sudden, unscheduled bathroom emergency is the *one* thing a planner can't spreadsheet around.

And that single emergency becomes the **domino**:

1. **Bladder emergency hits on the highway**. Not on the itinerary.
2. **The frantic dash to the restroom** — your cold-open.
3. **The dogs get loose because of the rush**.
4. **Now you're trapped at this unplanned stop** — and every second is daylight.

Does that causal chain feel right — the bladder as the trigger that frees the dogs?

USER

No, I don't like the bladder as the trigger. Let me drive for a minute

CLAUDE (game designer)

You got it — taking my hands off the wheel. I'm listening.

USER

You have to get to the bathroom quickly, because the dog's poop meter wasn't full initially, but is getting full. You have the car locked with the engine running and the heat or air conditioning is going (depending on the season, let's assume Summer). Thus, the driver HAS to get back to the car quickly, before Karen calls the cops for neglecting the dogs (when in reality, they're not being neglected as the vehicle is climate controlled).

CLAUDE (game designer)

Oh, that's much better — and it fixes a hole: *why would a responsible owner leave their dogs in the car at all?* Your answer: **because it's genuinely safe**. Locked, engine running, AC blasting.

And *that's* the comedy: **Karen doesn't know that**. She sees "three dogs alone in a car in summer" and her brain screams *hot car / neglect / call 911*. It rhymes perfectly with the Staffie bit.

So the threat-meter isn't the bladder anymore — it's **Karen's neglect panic**. The driver's bathroom trip is just *the reason they're away from the car*.

Here's the sequencing I think you're building toward:

- **Phase 1 — the quick break:** dash to the restroom yourself, leaving the dogs safe in the climate-controlled car. While you're gone, **Karen's neglect meter climbs**.
- **Phase 2 — the dog gauntlet:** you make it back, let the dogs out, and *that's* when the chase kicks off.

Is that the order — neglect-panic first, then escape/poop/scoop?

USER

Also the dogs might have an accident in the vehicle, so time is of the essence there as well

CLAUDE (game designer)

Yes — and that turns the **poop meter into the spine that runs the whole level**.

During Phase 1, while you're away, **two clocks run at once**:

- **Karen's neglect panic** (external/social) -> if it fills: she calls the cops.
- **The dogs' poop meter** (internal/biological) -> if it fills: **accident in the car**.

The poop meter doesn't *reset* between phases — it's **one continuous meter spanning the whole level**, and your *speed* decides where it resolves:

- **Too slow in Phase 1** -> it fills in the car -> accident inside.
- **Fast enough** -> in Phase 2 the job is to steer them to relieve themselves **in the designated zone** before it fills -> then scoop.

One pin: two timers both screaming "hurry" — we'll want to give them *slightly different speeds or tells* so the player feels two distinct threats.

USER

The order you proposed is correct. The only tweak is Karen doesn't notice at first that the dogs are unattended. If she notices, that ups the ante.

CLAUDE (game designer)

That tweak is better — it solves the redundancy concern. Now the two threats are *mechanically different things*:

- **The poop meter is the constant, inevitable clock.** Always ticking.
- **Karen is a conditional spike.** At first she hasn't clocked the dogs — no threat. But *if* she notices, the ante jumps.

So Phase 1 is "the poop clock is always running, and you're *hoping* you get in and out before Karen ever turns her head." A clean run where **Karen never even notices** feels genuinely skillful.

The key lever now: **what makes Karen notice?**

- **The dogs give themselves away** (agitation grows with the wait).
- **Karen's just on a path** (she patrols).
- **A mix.**

USER

a mix for sure

CLAUDE (game designer)

Nice — the mix has the most *texture*:

- **Karen wanders a path** around the lot — something the player can watch and learn.
- **The dogs get louder the longer they wait** — their "noise radius" grows.
- **She notices when those two collide** — an agitated dog *within range* of a wandering Karen.

So skill lowers your risk on *both* levers, but you can still get bitten by bad luck. That's the tension sweet spot: mostly earned, a little merciless. Very on-brand for a Karen.

Want me to **play the whole thing back as one clean recap** before we go further?

USER

I'll give you the wheel to do a clean recap that describes the game well and its whole point as you have ironed out.

CLAUDE (game designer)

[RECAP v1 delivered — protagonist, motivation, dogs, antagonist, master clock, the level's phases, all meters, win/lose, and mapping to the required pieces (three screens, high scores, local storage), plus the "whole point"

of the game.]

USER

The whole reason the driver stops is their pee meter is getting full.

CLAUDE (game designer)

Got it — that's a correction to my recap. I had Phase 1 starting because *the dogs* needed to go. Wrong. **The reason you pull in is the driver's own pee meter.**

That brings back the **bathroom-dash cold-open** — in the right role. You didn't want the bladder *causing the dogs to escape*. It isn't. The bladder is simply **why the planner stops**.

Corrected opening:

- **The pee meter forces the stop.**
- **Opening dash:** sprint to the restroom **before your own pee meter fills.**
- **While you're in there**, the *dogs'* clocks run on the parked car: poop meter + Karen's neglect panic.
- **Then** Phase 2: let the dogs out, Chihuahua bolts.

So you've got **three distinct meters** plus daylight above them all. Quick check: is the pee meter a real **fail-able race**, or purely **narrative**?

USER

No, if the pee meter fills before you stop, you have an accident and fail the game because you would have to clean up and clean up the car and daylight would be lost

CLAUDE (game designer)

Crystal clear — the pee meter is a **hard fail**. Fill it before you reach relief -> the driver has an accident -> clean yourself *and* the car -> so much lost daylight the run is dead. **Game over.**

So the pee meter is your **harshest, earliest gate**. It also teaches the player *immediately* that **daylight = life**.

Severity ladder:

1. **Pee accident -> instant game over.**
2. **Poop-in-car accident -> ? (open)**
3. **Karen calls cops -> the getaway branch.**
4. **Sun sets -> lost. Game over.**

One pin: the **dogs' in-car poop accident** — also a hard fail, or the *survivable* version (a big daylight hit)?

USER

If you were close to the scheduled break, you would have the choice to stop at the unscheduled rest stop before becoming full or risk it and try to make it to the scheduled stop.

CLAUDE (game designer)

Ooh — now you've added **player agency**, and it's the most *character-perfect* decision in the whole game:

- **Bail out:** take the unscheduled rest stop now, while the pee meter still has room. Safe — but a **deviation from The Plan**.
- **Risk it:** push for the **scheduled** stop. Stay on plan — but if the meter fills first, **game over**.

The irony: for a control freak, **sticking to the plan is the reckless choice**.

The one thing a gamble needs: **what do you win if you make it?** Since daylight is your currency, the natural answer is **winning the gamble banks you daylight**, while bailing early costs a little.

Key question: if you reach the scheduled stop, do you **skip the gauntlet**, or **still face the same rest-stop chaos** with bonus daylight banked? I'd lean toward the second.

USER

the poop in the car is a survivable accident

CLAUDE (game designer)

That asymmetry is exactly right:

- **Pee meter (you) -> fatal.**
- **Poop meter (dogs) -> survivable.** Gross, costly, humiliating — a big daylight hit — but you carry on.

Clean **severity ladder**:

1. **Pee accident** -> instant game over.
2. **Poop-in-car accident** -> heavy daylight hit, survivable.
3. **Karen calls the cops** -> the getaway branch.
4. **Sun sets** -> lost. Game over.

Still hanging: the **gamble payoff** — skip the gauntlet, or same level with a daylight bonus?

USER

the stops have Karen et al regardless of whether or not they're planned

CLAUDE (game designer)

That locks the gamble, and it's the funnier version: **planning doesn't save you. Karen is everywhere.**

- **One gauntlet per run.** Whichever stop you end up at has the dogs, the grass patch, the poop zone, and a Karen.
- **The opening gamble only sets your daylight stake:** bail early (safe, small daylight cost) vs. risk it (bank bonus daylight, or game over).

Bonus the structure hands you for free: the dogs are in the car *during the drive too*, so their **poop meter is also climbing while you gamble**. "Risk it" stacks two risks for one bigger reward.

You've closed every structural thread. The only things left are *implementation* details — controls/move-set and the look of the three screens. Want a fresh, final recap?

USER

Yes, please do a fresh recap

CLAUDE (game designer)

[RECAP v2 — the 'source of truth' — delivered. Covered: one-line pitch; theme; protagonist backstory & motivation; the three dogs as mechanics; antagonist Karen; the daylight master clock; the meters & severity ladder; the full flow (the opening Gamble, Phase 1 the quick break / neglect panic, Phase 2 the dog gauntlet ramp-up-then-combine, and the getaway punishment branch); mapping to all required pieces; and the whole point of the game.]

USER

Just making sure that you remember Karen will call the cops if one of the dogs poops in an undesignated area.

CLAUDE (game designer)

Got it — locked in. **Where the poop lands is itself a Karen trigger.** Three-way resolution of the poop meter:

- **Poops in the car (Phase 1)** -> *survivable*. Hidden inside your private vehicle, so **no Karen**.
- **Poops in an undesignated area outside (Phase 2)** -> **Karen pounces -> cops**.
- **Poops in the designated zone, then you scoop it** -> *clean win*.

So Phase 2 pressure is razor-sharp: steer the right dog into the designated zone **before** the meter fills.

Updated Karen cop-call triggers:

- **Phase 1:** she notices the unattended dogs.
- **Phase 2:** a dog **poops in an undesignated area**, OR poop is **left unscooped**, OR the **Staffie is in her sightline too long**, OR the **Lab body-slams** her.

USER

Write a short, two paragraph summary of the game for someone who might want to play it.

CLAUDE (game designer)

[Two-paragraph player-facing summary drafted, then revised twice for two corrections: (1) the destination is your sister's vacation home, not "home," and the danger is getting lost in the dark; (2) you're *starting your vacation* at your sister's vacation home. Final version below.]

REST STOP

You had a plan. You had a *binder*. A color-coded, minute-by-minute itinerary that would get you and your three dogs to your sister's vacation home — where your whole weekend getaway is set to begin — well before dark, because you do *not* drive at night, and those back roads are pitch-black and easy to get lost on. Then your bladder had other ideas. Now you're pulling into a rest stop that was never on the schedule, racing a sinking sun and your own body, and the only thing standing between you and the start of your vacation is a parking lot full of chaos and one very determined stranger who thinks she knows exactly what kind of person you are.

Rest Stop is a single-level, side-scrolling comedy of errors where **daylight is everything** — every fumble, every escaped dog, every accident burns the sunlight you need to reach your sister's place before nightfall swallows the roads and leaves you hopelessly lost, vacation not even started. Whatever daylight you've still got banked when you pull out of that lot is your score. Sprint to the restroom before disaster strikes, then wrangle your three wildly different dogs: corner the bolting Chihuahua, steer the over-friendly Labrador away from trouble, and keep your sweet, unfairly judged Staffordshire Terrier out of Karen's sight. Get a dog to do its business in the *designated* zone and scoop it before she pounces — or botch it, and you'll be flooring it out of the parking lot with the cops on the way. Keep your cool, read the chaos, beat the sunset.

USER

I need a PDF transcript of this conversation up to this point.